necessarily abandoning the earlier ones. The cumulative impression was thus of a steady and middle-of-the-road approach that gathered greater substance as India's influence grew. Having noted that, the truth is that ascending up the global ladder did require taking big calls, whether conventional or nuclear, political or economic. Not all risks are necessarily dramatic; many just require the confident calculations and determined follow through of day-to-day policy management. Their aggregate impact can result in a quantum jump in global positioning. To a certain degree, we see that happening today.

The fifth basket is in a return to the primer: reading the global tea leaves right. The foreign policy of all nations is set against the backdrop of global contradictions. They reflect an assessment of opportunities and compulsions, risks and rewards. Even if we are to get our immediate situation right, a misreading of the larger landscape can prove to be costly. In our own case, going to the UN on Jammu and Kashmir clearly misread the intent of the Anglo-American alliance and the seriousness of the Cold War. Years later, our early awareness about growing Sino-Soviet differences did not mature on our expected timelines. In the 1960s, 1980s and again after 2001, we underestimated the relevance of Pakistan to American and Chinese global strategy.

This is not to suggest that India has not had its successes. Indo-Soviet and later Indo-Russian relations are a direct product of our global strategizing. After 1991, so too has been the adjustment in our policy towards the US. Both the Indo-Soviet Treaty and the India-US Nuclear Deal were outcomes of a larger reading of world affairs. That is the case with correctives introduced in respect of the US in 1973 and China in 1976 to overcome the 1971 polarization with both. Identifying the opportunities thrown up by the structure of world politics can also help mitigate risks. We saw that, for example, in respect to France after the 1998 nuclear tests. Today, an appreciation of world politics must include a proper understanding of Sino-US contradictions, of growing multipolarity, of weaker multilateralism, of larger economic and political rebalancing, of greater space for regional powers, and of the world of convergences. Each of them is a factor in driving the policy initiatives of the present era. Whether it is our outreach to